

# THE THRESHOLD TEST

Five questions that separate AI value from AI activity.

## PREMISE

**88%** of organisations use AI in at least one function. **39%** report any EBIT contribution, and most of those put it below five percent of EBIT. Filter for material and McKinsey lands on **6%**. BCG, measuring the same thing on its own scale, lands on **5%**. Adoption is easy to count. Value needs a threshold, and the threshold has to be set before the work starts.

## 01 WHAT IS THE THRESHOLD, IN WRITING, BEFORE YOU START?

McKinsey's own line for a high performer is more than five percent of EBIT attributed to AI. Pick your number, write it down, date it.

**Catches** – success declared against a bar invented after the results arrived.

## 02 WHOSE P&L?

Enterprise level, or the unit where the system runs. The 39 percent figure is enterprise level, and the gap between the two is where most business cases quietly fail.

**Catches** – a unit-level win that never reaches the group P&L.

## 03 WHAT DOES THE MONEY REPLACE?

Headcount not hired. Contracts not renewed. Cycle time taken out of a process someone owns. If nothing gets smaller, nothing was saved.

**Catches** – productivity gains with no line item that moves.

## 04 WHAT BREAKS WHEN IT SCALES?

Every system that reaches production inherits a data boundary, an audit obligation and a failure mode with a named owner. Where no one owns the failure, the system does not leave the pilot, and the value never arrives.

**Catches** – the pilot that cannot pass its own risk review.

## 05 WHAT IS THE KILL CONDITION?

Which pilots stop, on what evidence, by what date. Decided in advance, by someone with the authority to stop them.

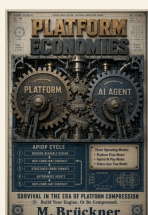
**Catches** – a portfolio that only ever grows.

## SCORING

**FIVE IN WRITING TODAY** – you are measuring value.

**THREE OR FOUR** – you have a business case and no verdict.

**TWO OR FEWER** – you are counting activity.



## PLATFORM ECONOMIES

Survival in the Era of Platform Compression.  
Mohammed Brückner

[platformeconomies.com](https://platformeconomies.com)

Figures: McKinsey, The State of AI, 2025.  
BCG, The Widening AI Value Gap, September 2025.